

Curriculum Vitae

Ali Safaya

asafaya19@ku.edu.tr

Koç University

Github:  alisafaya
Twitter:  ali_safaya
Semantic-Scholar:  Ali Safaya
ORCID:  0000-0003-0945-8897

Research Interests

Human Language Technologies, Natural Language Understanding, Story Understanding, Entity State Modeling

Education

May 2020— **Degree:** Doctor of Philosophy in Computer Science

July 2024 (expected) **Where:** Koç University, Istanbul, Turkey

GPA: 3.78 of 4.00

Currently a PhD research fellow at KUIS AI Center.

August 2015— **Degree:** Bachelor of Science in Computer Engineering

June 2019 **Where:** Sakarya University, Sakarya, Turkey

GPA: 3.89 of 4.00

Valedictorian for the graduation ceremony, for graduating with the highest GPA throughout the degree program.

Research

January 2021— **Project:** Turkish Data Depository

Present **Where:** KUIS AI Center, Koç University, Istanbul, Turkey

Advisor: Prof. Dr. Deniz Yuret

Contributions: I am leading three teams of researchers to develop datasets and tools for Turkish NLP. One example of our work was to deliver a new spell-checker to *LibreOffice* team for Turkish language. Also, we built a website to share all available Turkish NLP datasets in an open and documented manner. Another recent project is *Mukayese*: an extensive NLP benchmarking platform for Turkish, which provides test sets and baselines for most of NLP tasks. See tdd.ai.

September 2020— **Project:** Story Understanding and Entity State Modeling

Present **Where:** KUIS AI Center, Koç University, Istanbul, Turkey

Advisor: Prof. Dr. Deniz Yuret

Contributions: In this project, I am carrying out my PhD studies on a specific application of Natural Language Understanding, where I am working on story/narrative understanding and character/entity state modeling and tracking in long form documents. This is my main research focus for my PhD study.

August 2019— **Project:** ERC funded project of Emerging Markets Welfare

August 2020 **Where:** Koç University, Istanbul, Turkey

Advisor: Dr. Ali Hürriyetoglu

Contributions: I worked as Project Engineer on building a Protest Events Database using Natural Language Processing and Machine Learning, where I gained experience on being a part of a long term research project, and collaborating with interdisciplinary academics. I had the chance to co-organize workshops at top NLP venues like ACL and LREC during my work time on this project.

Employment

April 2021— **Position:** Lead ML/NLP Research Scientist

Present **Where:** Non-disclosable, USA

Developing solutions for various ML/NLP applications.

November 2017—
September 2020 **Position:** ML/NLP Engineer
 Where: Casemice Digital, Istanbul, Turkey
 Developing AutoML applications for persona-based chat-bots.

Teaching

2020—
Present **Position:** Teaching Assistant
 Where: Computer Science Dept., Koç University, Istanbul, Turkey
 I am working as a teaching assistant for Deep Learning *COMP-541*, and Natural Language Processing *COMP-542* courses.

Publications

- Aarohi Srivastava et al. “Beyond the Imitation Game: Quantifying and extrapolating the capabilities of language models”. In: *Computing Research Repository* arXiv:2206.04615 (2022). DOI: 10.48550/ARXIV.2206.04615. URL: <https://arxiv.org/abs/2206.04615>
- Ali Safaya et al. “Mukayese: Turkish NLP Strikes Back”. In: *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: ACL 2022*. Dublin, Ireland: Association for Computational Linguistics, May 2022, pp. 846–863. DOI: 10.18653/v1/2022.findings-acl.69. URL: <https://aclanthology.org/2022.findings-acl.69>
- Ali Hürriyetoğlu et al. “Event Coreference Resolution for Contentious Politics Events”. In: *Computing Research Repository* arXiv:2203.10123 (2022). DOI: 10.48550/ARXIV.2203.10123. URL: <http://arxiv.org/abs/2203.10123>
- Ali Safaya, Moutasem Abdullatif, and Deniz Yuret. “KUISAIL at SemEval-2020 Task 12: BERT-CNN for Offensive Speech Identification in Social Media”. In: *Proceedings of the Fourteenth Workshop on Semantic Evaluation*. Barcelona (online): International Committee for Computational Linguistics, 2020, pp. 2054–2059. URL: <https://aclanthology.org/2020.semeval-1.271>
- Ali Hürriyetoğlu et al. “Automated Extraction of Socio-political Events from News (AESPEN): Workshop and Shared Task Report”. English. In: *Proceedings of the Workshop on Automated Extraction of Socio-political Events from News 2020*. Marseille, France: European Language Resources Association (ELRA), 2020, pp. 1–6. ISBN: 979-10-95546-50-4. URL: <https://aclanthology.org/2020.aespen-1.1>
- Ali Hürriyetoğlu et al. “COVCOR20 at WNUT-2020 Task 2: An Attempt to Combine Deep Learning and Expert rules”. In: *Proceedings of the Sixth Workshop on Noisy User-generated Text (W-NUT 2020)*. Online: Association for Computational Linguistics, 2020, pp. 495–498. DOI: 10.18653/v1/2020.wnut-1.75. URL: <https://aclanthology.org/2020.wnut-1.75>
- Ali Safaya. “Event Sentence Detection Task using Attention model”. In: *Working Notes of CLEF 2019 - Conference and Labs of the Evaluation Forum, 07*. Lugano, Switzerland: CEUR Workshop Proceedings, 2019. URL: http://ceur-ws.org/Vol-2380/paper_122.pdf

Presentations

- Ali Safaya. *Reproducing Single Headed Attention - Recurrent Neural Networks*. Seminar presented at KUIS AI meeting, Istanbul (online), 2020

Languages

- Arabic — Native-Bilingual Proficiency
- English — Working Proficiency
- Turkish — Native-Bilingual Proficiency

Honors and awards

- KUIS AI Center Fellowship (2020 — present)
- Turkish NLP Hackathon — 1st place award (2021)
- Inzva Computer Engineering PhD Scholarship (2020 — 2021)
- Graduated with Honor Degree of BS program (Valedictorian of 2019)
- Türkiye Scholarship (2015 — 2019)